



The Humanitas Institute

## Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Aquinas Academy

School Website: <https://aquinasacademy.com/>

December 21, 2025

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**Disclaimer**

*This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.*

**ACCS Member School**

*Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.*

## Executive Summary TL;DR

- School reviewed: Arcadia Christian School (Arcadia, CA) — “ACS Journey towards Christian Classical Education.” Overall status: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.
- Highlights: Clear theological grounding (Scripture/biblical worldview), explicit Trivium language (grammar–logic–rhetoric), intent to implement reading in the classics and Socratic discussion. Evidence of community education via posted “Guide to Classical” resources.
- Gaps to close: Little or no public mention of liturgical/chapel life, “truth–goodness–beauty” language, scholē/restful learning, K–8 chant/recitation practices, teacher formation/portrait, and explicit parent partnership structures.
- Trajectory: Up and to the right. If ACS makes a few targeted, public-facing additions and practices, it can credibly cross from SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL to CLASSICAL within the next cycle.

## Source set used

- School crawl data from [arcadiachristianschool.org](http://arcadiachristianschool.org) (pages describing ACS's “Journey towards Christian Classical Education,” Trivium, classics, and Socratic discussion; plus community-facing Classical guides) .
- Framework: Six Essential Elements of a Classical School (Positive/Negative Keyword Indicators and criteria) .
- Supplementary lexicon of classical indicators used for matching nuance and families of terms .

Note on method: For each category below, I (1) list keywords/phrases that appear in ACS's own public materials; (2) compare them to the Six Elements' Positive/Negative indicators; (3) quantify positive vs. negative matches observed; and (4) assign a score.

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## Classicality Audit: Arcadia Christian School

### CATEGORY 1: RELIGIOUS AND METAPHYSICAL FOUNDATIONS

#### 1) Keywords found on ACS site (direct quotes/phrases):

- “Scripture at every point is the foundation on which to build all knowledge” (Scripture, foundation, knowledge, God) .
- “continuing to teach from a biblical worldview in all subjects” (biblical worldview) .
- “training and equipping them in faith, character, heart, and service” (faith, character) .

#### 2) Comparison to Six Elements indicators:

- Positive matches: sacred scripture, Christian worldview, theology—direct alignment with “Grounded in Theology” indicators (e.g., sacred scripture, Christian worldview) .

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- Missing or weak: Explicit transcendental language (truth–goodness–beauty), and explicit “Liturgical and Communal Practices” terms (chapel, liturgy, hymnody, common prayer) are not present in the reviewed pages .

3) Quantitative estimate:

- Positive keyword matches observed: 4 (Scripture, biblical worldview, God, faith).
- Negative keyword matches observed: 0 (no “values-neutral”/“secular”/“relativism” language detected).
- Estimated positive vs. negative ratio: 100% positive among detected terms; however, only ~40–50% of the category’s full positive indicator set appears publicly (no T–G–B or liturgy terms).

4) Category score: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Strong theological grounding is evident; public evidence of transcendental language and liturgical life is not yet visible.

## CATEGORY 2: SCHOOL PURPOSE AND GOAL

1) Keywords found on ACS site:

- “teach our students not what to think, but how to think!” (how to think) .
- “training and equipping them in faith, character, heart, and service” (formation/character) .
- “embracing a classical method” (classical method) .

2) Comparison to Six Elements indicators:

- Positive indicators emphasize cultivation of wisdom and virtue; formation not information; and pursuit of truth, goodness, and beauty .
- Direct matches present: character, formation-leaning language (“training and equipping”), “how to think” (logic/dialectic orientation).
- Missing: explicit “truth, goodness, beauty,” “wisdom,” and “virtue” terms on the reviewed pages.

3) Quantitative estimate:

- Positive keyword matches observed (direct): 2–3 (character, think/how to think; classical method).
- Negative keyword matches: 0 (no “college and career ready,” “21st-century skills,” “workforce prep” emphases) .
- Estimated positive vs. negative ratio: ~90–100% positive among detected terms; breadth of explicit classical purpose language is partial.

4) Category score: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- The ends of education are framed as formation in thinking and character, but explicit transcendental and “wisdom/virtue” terminology is not yet public-facing.

## CATEGORY 3: SCHOOL CURRICULUM

1) Keywords found on ACS site:

- “reading in the classics” (classics/Great Books orientation) and “Socratic discussion” .
- “memorization—grammar stage; argument—logic stage; analysis and expression—rhetoric stage” (Trivium: grammar, logic, rhetoric) .
- “We call this the TRIVIUM” (explicit Trivium) .

2) Comparison to Six Elements indicators:

- Positive indicators: Seven Liberal Arts/Trivium, Great Books/primary sources, historical engagement, integration/wonder .
- Direct positive matches: grammar, logic, rhetoric (Trivium), classics, Socratic method—all present and explicitly stated.

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3) Quantitative estimate:

- Positive keyword matches observed: 5–7 (classics, Socratic, grammar, logic, rhetoric, Trivium).
- Negative keyword matches: 0 (no “social studies” replacing history; no STEM-first/“project-based dominance”).
- Estimated positive vs. negative ratio: 100% positive among detected terms; breadth is good.

4) Category score: CLASSICAL

- ACS publicly names the Trivium and Socratic approach and signals reading in the classics—core curriculum markers are present.

## **CATEGORY 4: SCHOOL PEDAGOGY OR TEACHING METHODS**

1) Keywords found on ACS site:

- “Socratic discussion” (Socratic seminar/dialectic).
- “memorization—grammar stage” (recitation/memory work implied).
- Trivium stages emphasizing argument/logic and expression/rhetoric (upper-school rhetoric orientation).

2) Comparison to Six Elements indicators:

- Positive indicators: Socratic dialogue, restful learning (scholé), memorization/recitation/chanting, and formation through imitation.
- Direct matches: Socratic dialogue and memorization.
- Missing: explicit “scholé/restful,” “chanting/singing,” and “imitation/progymnasmata” language on the reviewed pages.

3) Quantitative estimate:

- Positive keyword matches observed: 2–3 (Socratic, memorization, logic/rhetoric).
- Negative keyword matches: 0 (no “project-based only,” “experiential learning focus,” or “student-directed constructivism” language).
- Estimated positive vs. negative ratio: ~100% positive among detected terms; but breadth is partial.

4) Category score: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Strong Socratic/Trivium signals; add explicit scholé and chant/recitation practices to round out classical pedagogy.

Note: If ACS is K–8 only, classical pedagogy can still be complete without heavy seminar rhetoric; nevertheless, ACS does already point to Socratic discussion and rhetoric-stage aims, which is encouraging.

## **CATEGORY 5: SCHOOL FACULTY**

1) Keywords found on ACS site:

- No public-facing statements found in the crawl about teacher portrait/virtue modeling, “faculty of friends,” or teacher formation in classical pedagogy.

2) Comparison to Six Elements indicators:

- Positive indicators include teachers as models of virtue, mentorship/collegiality, “living curriculum,” and explicit teacher profile/portrait.

3) Quantitative estimate:

- Positive keyword matches observed: 0.
- Negative keyword matches observed: 0 (no “facilitator only”/jargon without classical context).

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- Evidence gap: high.
- 4) Category score: NOT CLASSICAL (insufficient public evidence)
- Recommend adding a teacher portrait, faculty formation language, and virtue-modeling expectations publicly.

## **CATEGORY 6: SCHOOL PARENTS AND COMMUNITY**

- 1) Keywords found on ACS site:
- Community education resources: ACS hosts “Guide to Classical” (English and Chinese) and an “ACS Journey towards Christian Classical Education” video series—clear signals of parent/community formation efforts .
  - “Learn more” and posting of CAP resources for the community (parent formation proxy) .
- 2) Comparison to Six Elements indicators:
- Positive indicators: partnership with families/co-teachers, parent formation (book studies/seminars), cultural transmission events and communication .
  - Direct “parent partnership/co-teacher” language is not evident in the pages crawled; however, publishing parent-friendly Classical guides indicates movement toward parent formation.
- 3) Quantitative estimate:
- Positive keyword signals observed: 1–2 (community-facing “Guide to Classical,” learning resources).
  - Negative keyword matches: 0 (no “parents as customers only” tone) .
  - Estimated positive vs. negative ratio: ~100% positive among limited detected signals; breadth is partial.
- 4) Category score: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Evidence of parent/community education is present; add explicit “parent partnership” commitments, parent covenant, and ongoing formation events.

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## **Overall Aggregate Rating: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL**

Rationale: ACS has publicly committed to a Christian classical direction with clear theological grounding and strong curriculum/pedagogy signals (Trivium, classics, Socratic), plus early evidence of community formation. To be fully CLASSICAL per the Six Elements framework, ACS should surface more explicit transcendental (truth–goodness–beauty) language, liturgical/chapel life, restful learning and chant/recitation in the lower school, teacher formation/portrait, and a clear parent partnership model in its public materials .

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### **What would move the needle (actionable, public-facing steps)**

- Religious and Metaphysical Foundations
  - Add explicit transcendental language (truth, goodness, beauty), moral realism, and ordered loves to the mission and academics pages .
  - Publish chapel/liturgy rhythms (daily/weekly chapel, common prayer, hymnody) to signal the school’s sacred communal life .
- School Purpose and Goal
  - State clearly that education pursues wisdom and virtue and is “formation, not merely information,” and tie this to the school’s telos (human flourishing oriented to the true, good, and beautiful) .
- Curriculum

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- Post a representative “classics/Great Books” list by grade bands; ensure “history” (not “social studies”) is used prominently; show integration/wonder statements across subjects .
  - Pedagogy
    - Name restful learning (scholé) as part of the school’s cadence; highlight lower school singing/chanting/recitation practices in daily routines (a hallmark of classical memory culture) . For lower grades especially, routine chant/sing practices are strongly classical and form memory and affections .
  - Faculty
    - Publish a “Portrait of a Teacher” describing teachers as models of virtue, mentors, and lifelong learners formed in classical pedagogy; highlight ongoing faculty formation in Great Books/seminars .
  - Parents and Community
    - Make the parent partnership explicit (co-teachers in formation), add a parent covenant, and list regular parent formation events (book clubs, seminars, Infosessions on the liberal arts) .
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## **Appendix: Element-by-Element Keyword Tallies (direct matches seen vs. framework)**

- Religious & Metaphysical: Positive 4 (Scripture, biblical worldview, God, faith); Negative 0. Missing: T–G–B; liturgy/chapel .
  - Purpose & Goal: Positive 2–3 (character, how to think, classical method); Negative 0; Missing: wisdom/virtue/T–G–B words .
  - Curriculum: Positive 5–7 (classics, Socratic, grammar, logic, rhetoric, Trivium); Negative 0; Missing: posted Great Books list, history-not-social-studies proof .
  - Pedagogy: Positive 2–3 (Socratic, memorization, logic/rhetoric); Negative 0; Missing: explicit scholé, chanting/singing, imitation/progymnasmata .
  - Faculty: Positive 0; Negative 0; Missing: teacher portrait/formation language .
  - Parents & Community: Positive 1–2 (community-facing Guide to Classical, CAPS resources); Negative 0; Missing: explicit “parent partnership/co-teachers,” covenant, recurring parent formation schedule .
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# Appendix

## ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

### Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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